a secretary. It was different at a book publisher's, particularly a large one.

Doubleday was, of course, a large one, and already by 1952, my small peculiarities were becoming known and allowed for. It was taken for granted that things would be noisy when I was around, and any young woman I overlooked in my all-embracing suavity was liable to be offended.

Doubleday's offices, at each of the four different midtown buildings they occupied since I have known them, usually occupied several floors, each floor a rabbit warren of offices that are not particularly built for privacy. Secretaries usually sit out in the corridors and if the editors have offices, these have doors that are, characteristically, always open.

This meant that when I came in, my voice rebounded off distant walls and it was not merely my own immediate editor and secretary who knew of my presence.

My attitude toward young women amused everyone generally, I think, and the amusement was intensified, I think, by the general impression (frequently expressed out loud) that I was harmless. I even suspect that new girls were warned of my feckless lechery in advance so that they wouldn't run screaming or, worse yet, bop me on the nose. At least none of them ever did either. Mostly they just kissed back.

What struck me most forcibly about any editor's office, by the way (once I got my eyes off the young women), were the books. Every office consists largely of bookshelves.

But, then, that is what editors do—read. They read books and manuscripts and galleys and letters. They read not so much at work, where they are distracted by phone calls, conferences, and visits from loudmouthed cheerful authors such as myself, and snarling, com-, plaining authors such as everyone else, but at home, where, apparently, they read till they fall asleep, face-down, on a manuscript, to begin again when they wake up bleary-eyed.

Why they do it, I don't know. I have never known an editor, from

Campbell on, who didn't fill his or her life with 176 hours a week of work—and who wasn't underpaid.

But there are compensations. When my present Doubleday editor, Cathleen Jordan, a mere slip of a girl, frowns—I tremble. That must be a delightful feeling of power that they have.